

THE ONE RULE

30 minutes of hard straining (or of your own trying) without progress = RING THE VET. A too-early call costs a phone call; a late one can cost the ewe and the lamb.

3–6 h stage 1 (restless, pawing)	30–60 min water bag → lamb born	≤ 2 h lamb's first suck	50 ml/kg first colostrum feed (200 ml @ 4 kg)	39–40 °C normal lamb temp · <37 °C = severe	≤ 6 h placenta passed (vet at 18 h)
WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY MEANING	DO	URGENCY		
Straining 30 min, nothing appearing	Lamb stuck / not entering canal	Ring vet now · pen her calmly · kit ready for vet	RED		
Water bag 1 h ago, no lamb	Stalled stage 2	Ring vet now	RED		
Two hooves soles-down + nose	Normal “diver”	Watch — lamb within ~30 min; progress every 10–15 min	GREEN		
One foot + nose only	Front leg back	Ring vet · do not pull	RED		
Head out, no feet	Both legs back — shoulders jam	Ring vet · keep head moist (clean wet towel) · never pull the head	RED		
Feet advance, no nose follows	Head turned back	Ring vet · do not pull	RED		
Tail only / soft dome, weak straining	Breech — fools you: she may seem calm	Ring vet even if she seems fine	RED		
Two hooves soles-UP, no nose	Hind legs first — cord pinches, must be fast	Ring vet · assist only with experienced help / phone guidance	AMBER→RED		
Soles up AND a nose	Lamb upside down	Ring vet · do not pull	RED		
3+ legs, mixed directions	Two lambs together	Ring vet — expert sorting	RED		
Hard straining between twins >30 min	Next lamb stuck	Ring vet	RED		
Lamb born, not breathing	Airway blocked / stunned	Clear nose NOW → straw-tickle nostril → rub chest hard → brief head-down drain → repeat · ring vet at 1 min	RED		
Lamb cold / weak / floppy	Hypothermia ± starvation	Thermometer. 37–39 °C: dry, feed, warm. <37 °C + over ~5 h old: DO NOT WARM FIRST — vet (needs glucose first)	RED		
Lamb won't suck by 2 h	Starvation clock running	Clear udder wool, strip teats, guide lamb · milk ewe + bottle 50 ml/kg if it can swallow · tube = trained only	AMBER→RED		
Smooth pink ball at vulva (pre-lambing)	“Bearing” — vaginal prolapse	Pen her · clean wet lukewarm towel over it · ring vet	RED		
LARGE red mass with button bumps (post-lambing)	Uterine prolapse	Keep her still · cover with clean wet towel, off the ground · ring vet NOW — say “uterine prolapse”	RED		
Fresh blood dripping / running / pooling	Haemorrhage (streaks are normal)	Keep her still · ring vet now · pack nothing	RED		
Membranes hanging >18 h	Retained placenta	Ring vet · NEVER pull (trim below hocks only)	AMBER		
Ewe down / dopey / “blind” / trembling	Sleepy sickness · milk fever · other	Prop upright on chest · shelter · ring vet NOW · never drench a flat ewe	RED		

VET (DAY) _____ VET (AFTER HOURS) _____

BACKUP CLINIC _____ EXPERIENCED CONTACT _____

PROPERTY ADDRESS FOR VET _____